Daniel Mandragona

ML Performance Engineer | TPU Kernels · Distributed LLM Training · Quantum Computing

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EXPERIENCE

Google

Sep 2018 – Aug 2022; Sep 2024 – Present

Machine Learning Engineer *Mountain View, CA*

ML Performance Engineering — JAX Models & Performance Apr 2026 – Present

DeepSeek-V3 671B Pretraining — MLPerf 6.1

- Led the design and realization of an experimental batch-split pipelined DeepSeek-V3 implementation into a fully MLPerf-compliant submission at 8,192-chip scale.
- Stabilized MoE training: analyzed expert-load imbalance across all 58 sparse layers, reconciled subtle aux-LB loss & dynamic router-bias differences, restored exact FP32 router biases, and debugged a critical dataset issue resulting in faster convergence (53 → 43 steps) and +15% E2E tok/s.
- Overlapped shared experts with SparseCore combine reduce-scatters; coalesced and pipelined cross-slice (DCN) gradient all-reduces across the expert axis (+11% E2E tok/s at 8,192-chip scale).
- Drove the move from multi-slice 4×4×N to single-slice 8×A×B meshes: remapped 3D collectives, fit expert FSDP shards to whole FP8 tiles, and cut 18 relayout copies/step.

TPU Kernel Engineering

- Upstreamed MaxText's mHC-lite Pallas kernel: VMEM-fused norm/projection/gating, closed-form bwd math (sidestepping slow autodiff), and packed MXU contractions; up to 2.6× vs. pure JAX, +15% E2E tok/s on a customer LLM.
- Built an E2E hybrid-precision Pallas S5 SSM kernel for Oxford FLAIR's LOBS5 limit-order-book model: 2× faster training step than pure-JAX associative scan at 12k sequence length.
- Reformulated complex-valued contractions in a Pallas TPU FFT kernel for a 25% speedup.
- Advised on a chunked Gated DeltaNet pretraining Pallas kernel (2.2× fwd + bwd time); derived the closed-form backward gradient-flow diagram used to verify correctness across the chunked recurrence.
- Eliminated row-max reductions in FP8 Splash Attention via fixed-ceiling softmax and a fused dynamic norm-bound gate: −22% fwd kernel at 4k, −44% at 128k, and −12–16% step time at 128k–256k without underflow.

Distributed Training & Customer Engagements

- Engineered async host offloading for hybrid-attention scans in MaxText: +15% tok/s, −20% peak HBM on a customer LLM.
- Cut a flagship customer's MoE proxy step time 51% (451 → 223 ms) via Ring-of-Experts EP, Pallas ragged sort, GMM v2, projection fusion, and 2-chunk comm/compute overlap.
- Reduced Wan 2.1 (14B) diffusion step time 25% via Unified Sequence Parallelism (Ring Attention + DeepSpeed-Ulysses).

Quantum AI (20% project) 2025 – Present

- Designed a TPU-accelerated real-time maximum-likelihood QEC decoder (patent pending).
- Accelerated Tesseract QEC decoder 5.6× on the d=23 surface code via arena allocation, linked lists & software prefetching.
- Characterized Two-Level-System (TLS) qubit defects via Gaussian-mixture/skew-normal fits and computer-vision tracking.

Certificate Authority Infrastructure — Google Trust Services 2019 – 2022; 2024 – 2026

- Eliminated low-level CA bottlenecks across Go/C interop, DB hotspot thrashing, network egress, and DNS resolver latency.
- Designed load balancing for atypical network constraints; migrated servers into hardened, high-security machine pools.
- Implemented ACME (RFC 8555), hardened the CA for public launch, and supported WebTrust audits and key ceremonies.
- Discovered and reported a high-severity DoS vulnerability (CVE-2019-17596) in Go's crypto/dsa package.

Google Research — Perception & Play Abuse 2018 – 2019

- Built ML pipelines for image-saliency prediction (ResNet U-Net) and multimodal Google Play abuse detection.

EDUCATION

M.S. Mathematics (GPA 3.93) · Texas A&M University, College Station, TX — Aug 2022 – Dec 2024

B.S. Mathematics, Computational Sciences (GPA 3.71) · University of Central Florida, Orlando, FL — Aug 2013 – May 2018

PRESENTATIONS

QEC: From Classical Errors to the Surface Code — Quantum AI, Google — Oct 2025

Berry Phase & Chern Numbers — Master's Presentation, TAMU — Nov 2024

Quantum Markov Chains — Quantum Algorithms, CSCE 640, TAMU — Nov 2023

PUBLICATIONS

A Chaotic Chemical Reactor With and Without Delay: Bifurcations, Competitive Modes, and Amplitude Death.

S. Roy Choudhury and Daniel Mandragona. *Int. J. Bifurc. Chaos*, 2019.

SKILLS

Languages & Frameworks: Python · C++ · Golang · C · JAX · Pallas · XLA / HLO

ML Systems: TPU Kernels · Distributed Sharding & Collectives · Quantization · MoE · XProf · Roofline Analysis